



NOVEMBER – MONITORING, PATIENCE AND WINTER PREPARATION

November is often one of the quietest months in the beekeeping year.

The colonies have largely completed their winter preparations.

Honey harvesting is long finished.

Varroa treatments should already be complete.

Most feeding should have been carried out.

The beekeeper's role now becomes one of observation rather than intervention.

For many people, this can be surprisingly difficult.

After months of regular inspections and hive management, November demands patience.

The bees generally know what they are doing.

Our job is simply to make sure they have everything they need to survive until spring.

WEATHER, TEMPERATURE AND SHORT DAYS

November marks the beginning of genuine winter conditions across much of the UK.

Temperatures continue to fall.

Daylight hours become noticeably shorter.

Flying opportunities become increasingly limited.

Strong winds, heavy rain and the first frosts become common.

The landscape changes dramatically.

Many forage sources have disappeared entirely.

The colony is now dependent almost entirely upon stored food.

The bees understand this.

Every action within the hive is focused on conserving energy.

WHAT YOUR BEES ARE DOING

By November, many colonies have formed a winter cluster for significant periods.

The cluster is not permanent.

On mild days, bees may still fly to take cleansing flights or investigate local forage.



However, activity is greatly reduced compared with summer.

Brood rearing is often minimal.

Some colonies may become almost broodless.

Others may maintain small areas of brood depending on weather and genetics.

The winter bees produced during late summer now become the colony's most important resource.

These bees must survive until spring.

Everything depends upon them.

THE IMPORTANCE OF FOOD STORES

Food remains the single most important consideration during November.

A colony can survive cold weather remarkably well.

It cannot survive without food.

This is why experienced beekeepers continue to monitor hive weight throughout winter.

Hefting remains one of the simplest and most useful skills.

A hive that suddenly feels lighter than expected deserves attention.

REALITY CHECK: Colonies rarely die because it was cold. They frequently die because they ran out of food.

WHEN TO USE FONDANT

By November, liquid syrup is often no longer practical.

Temperatures may be too low for bees to process it effectively.

Fondant becomes the preferred emergency feed.

Many beekeepers place fondant on colonies that feel light or keep supplies ready in case conditions deteriorate.

The aim is not to replace proper autumn feeding.

The aim is to provide insurance.

A small amount of preparation now can prevent major losses later.

RESIST THE URGE TO INSPECT

One of the hardest lessons for new beekeepers is learning when not to open a hive.



BeezKnees – November Apiary Master Guide

November apiary master guide for cool, temperate UK climate

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November is usually not the time for routine inspections.

Every unnecessary disturbance forces the colony to use energy.

Opening hives can chill brood and disrupt cluster organisation.

Most information can be gathered without dismantling the colony.

Useful checks include:

- Hive weight
- Entrance activity
- Signs of damage
- Storm impacts
- Evidence of pests
- Condition of roofs and straps

Observation often tells you more than inspection during winter.

WATCHING FOR WINTER PROBLEMS

Although colonies are largely left alone, November is still a month for vigilance.

Problems occasionally become visible from outside the hive.

Things worth monitoring include:

- Unusually high bee mortality
- Signs of robbing
- Water ingress
- Damaged roofs
- Fallen straps
- Animal damage
- Blocked entrances

Most issues are easier to solve when discovered early.

Small winter problems can become serious by spring if ignored.

MICE, WOODPECKERS AND OTHER PESTS

As temperatures fall, wildlife becomes increasingly interested in beehives.

Mice are one of the most common concerns.



A hive provides warmth, shelter and protection from predators.

Without mouse guards, rodents may enter and cause significant damage.

In some locations, woodpeckers may also become a problem.

Repeated pecking can damage equipment and disturb winter clusters.

November is therefore a good month to confirm all physical protections remain secure.

DAMP AND CONDENSATION

Cold temperatures rarely kill healthy colonies.

Damp conditions are far more dangerous.

Warm air generated by the cluster naturally contains moisture.

When this moisture meets cold surfaces, condensation develops.

If water drips onto the cluster, problems quickly follow.

Many winter hive losses are linked to moisture rather than temperature.

Good roof insulation and sensible ventilation remain important throughout November.

REALITY CHECK: A dry colony can tolerate surprisingly cold weather. A wet colony struggles far more.

REVIEWING THE SEASON

November is an excellent month to reflect on the year.

Questions worth asking include:

- Which colonies performed best?
- Which queens would you keep?
- Which colonies required the most intervention?
- What equipment was missing when you needed it?
- What would you do differently next year?

Good records become particularly valuable during winter.

Many improvements for next season begin with honest reflection during November.



WINTER LEARNING AND EDUCATION

While the bees are quieter, many beekeepers focus on improving their own knowledge.

Winter is an excellent time to:

- Attend association meetings
- Join study groups
- Read beekeeping books
- Watch educational talks
- Prepare for BBKA examinations
- Plan future apiary expansion

The best time to improve beekeeping knowledge is often when the bees require the least attention.

PREPARING FOR DECEMBER

November acts as a bridge between autumn and winter.

The preparations made during August, September and October should now be complete.

The focus shifts almost entirely towards monitoring and support.

Food availability.

Weather protection.

Pest prevention.

Minimal disturbance.

These become the priorities.

December often brings even less colony activity and greater reliance on winter stores.

Colonies entering December strong, healthy and well-provisioned have the best chance of thriving in spring.

NOVEMBER TAKEAWAY

November is a month that rewards patience.

Most of the important work should already have been completed.

The beekeeper's role is no longer to manage growth.



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It is to monitor quietly and intervene only when necessary.

Check stores.

Protect against pests.

Keep hives dry.

Prepare for winter.

Then allow the bees to do what they have evolved to do for thousands of years.

Survive until spring.

REALITY CHECK: The best November management is often simple:
Watch carefully, disturb little, and make sure the bees never run out of food.